CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

ARBORIST / TREE PRO IN THE AI ERA

Trees keep growing, storms keep knocking them down, and the work happens sixty feet up with a chainsaw.

★ TL;DR — Around $75K median for skilled tree work you can start learning in 1–6 months, no license required to start. The catch: it is one of the most physically dangerous trades there is. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

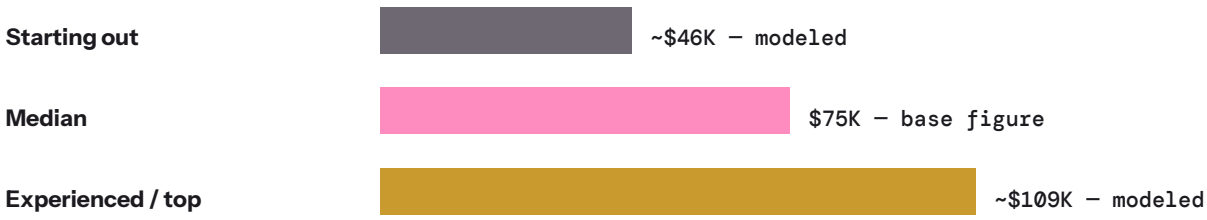
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Why it works: trees never stop growing, dying and falling on things — the work is permanently local.
- Where it bites: heights, chainsaws and falling wood make this a safety-obsessed profession.
- The AI angle: AI can spot diseased trees in drone photos; it cannot climb one and cut it down in pieces.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Arborist / Tree Pro is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A ARBORIST / TREE PRO ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Climb or use a lift to prune, shape and remove trees section by section
- ✓ Rig ropes so cut pieces land where you want, not on the roof
- ✓ Grind stumps, chip brush and haul away debris
- ✓ Assess tree health and storm damage and explain options to the owner

Think: a surgeon who works at altitude — every cut is planned, rigged and irreversible.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Drone surveys, mapping software and photo-based health assessments are taking over the inspection layer. Quotes and scheduling get more automated every year.	The climbing, rigging and cutting stay human. Every tree leans differently, rots differently and punishes a lazy plan differently — that read is experience, not software.

⚠ **Tree work sits near the top of occupational injury lists. Training, gear checks and a good crew are not optional extras.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Outside all day, in a different yard every day ✓ Real craft: rope systems, rigging math, saw skill ✓ Storm weeks are brutal and very well paid	✗ Heights and chainsaws, combined, daily ✗ Your body takes the bill: shoulders, knees, back ✗ Weather decides your schedule more than you do

Good fit? You are fit, calm at height, and the kind of person who checks their knots twice without being told.
Bad fit? Heights bother you, details bore you, or you want work that leaves your body alone.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — GROUND CREW FIRST	DOOR B — TREE CARE COMPANY TRAINEE
Nearly every climber starts on the ground: dragging brush, running ropes, feeding the chipper. You learn rigging and saw handling from below while the crew watches whether you are safe enough to send up.	Larger tree services run structured trainee tracks with climbing instruction and gear provided. Slower to the top sometimes, but the safety culture and certifications on the way make you portable.

Smart move: Get seriously good at rigging, not just cutting — the climber who can lower a huge piece over a glass roof without drama is the one who gets named in reviews.

Where you land after: Lead climber, crew foreman, plant-health specialist, or your own tree service with a chipper and a waiting list.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
START ON	LEARN THE	FIRST CLIMBS	RIGGING AND	ADD PLANT	PICK YOUR

STEP 1 — Start on the ground

PAID · WEEKS 1-4

- Get hired as ground crew with a local tree company
- Learn knots, rope handling and chipper safety from day one

STEP 2 — Learn the saw on the ground

ON THE JOB · MONTHS 1-2

- Bucking, limbing and maintenance until saw work is boring and safe
- Study basic tree biology: species, decay, weak unions

STEP 3 — First climbs

SUPERVISED · MONTHS 2-4

- Climb with modern rope systems under a lead climber
- Prune small trees fully before touching removals

STEP 4 — Rigging and removals

SUPERVISED · MONTHS 3-6

- Learn negative rigging and piece-by-piece takedowns
- Practice reading lean, rot and wind before the first cut

STEP 5 — Add plant health care

MONTHS 4-6

- Learn pruning standards and common pest and disease signs
- Health work is steadier and easier on the body than removals

STEP 6 — Pick your climb

MONTH 6

- Production climbing pays now; health care pays longer
- Either way, keep the safety record spotless — it is your resume

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: learn ten basic knots and list the tree companies within driving distance.

- Days 1–30: work ground crew; master brush, ropes and the chipper.
- Days 31–60: saw work on the ground and first supervised climbs.
- Days 61–90: prune small trees start to finish with a lead watching.
- Day 90: you are real crew — the climb to lead arborist is measured in seasons, not weeks.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ THE TREE DECIDES. YOU PLAN ANYWAY. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.